

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

GENERAL ASSEMBLY

Energy measure OK'd by House

Boost for batteries aims to make wind, solar more efficient

By Jeremy Gorner, John Lippert and Olivia Olander
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — The Illinois House passed sweeping energy-related measures in the waning days of the General Assembly's fall veto legislative session, backing the use of big batteries to help make wind and solar power more effective but raising questions about whether the legislation will increase or decrease energy bills.

House Democrats said the legislation would eventually lower electric bills for Illinois consumers burdened by utility rate spikes driven by rising power grid demand, while Republicans noted the massive battery installations would be backed in part by a surcharge on consumers' monthly bills.

The disagreement, mostly along party lines, was reflected in the final 70-37 House vote Wednesday night on the 1,020-page energy bill, which was being taken up by the Senate late Thursday, the final day of veto session and the last scheduled legislative day of 2025.

As the energy bill cleared one chamber, long-awaited legislation to reform and fund Chicago-area mass transit had yet to advance, even as discussions continued late Thursday and top leaders negotiated privately in an attempt to rescue the initiative.

On the energy front, Democratic lawmakers who hold supermajorities in the House and Senate have been unable to convince their Republican counterparts, particularly those downstate who've repeatedly raised alarms in the last several months about increased utility rates, that the energy policy changes would lower electric bills.

The bill is a result of negotiations between lawmakers, organized labor, environmental interests and other

Turn to Energy, Page 2

'Hardship in our communities is going to skyrocket': Illinois SNAP recipients, nonprofits, pantries brace for halt of federal food stamp funding as politicians cast blame for shutdown



Yasmin Rodríguez, right, helps Joanna Martínez, a SNAP recipient, load food items into a shopping cart Oct. 22 at the Northwestern Settlement food pantry in Chicago. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Hungry for help

Amid ICE fears, SNAP cuts, Chicagoland neighbors are pulling together to stuff thousands of goodie bags and make the best of Halloween holiday

By Tess Kenny
Chicago Tribune

A Dum-Dums lollipop, one pack of Swedish Fish — or Sour Patch Kids — Lifesavers gummies and a Reese's cup, plus a hand-signed note.

Around Bobbie Aguilera, piles of candy lay strewn across folding tables as fellow neighbors filled their own assortment of plastic goodie bags, each bound for families who will be staying inside come Friday night as their concerns about safety shroud trick-or-treating plans.

"This is someone's Halloween," Aguilera said as she packed the treats into a small zip-close bag in a second-floor room of Irving Park's Kilbourn Fieldhouse Monday night.

With both the Trump

Turn to Halloween, Page 5



Bobbie Aguilera and Juliana Terroba, 9, assemble candy packages for families too afraid to trick-or-treat this year at the Kilbourn Park Fieldhouse in the Irving Park neighborhood on Monday. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Judge skeptical of SNAP suspension

As 25 states pressed to preserve funding for SNAP benefits, a federal judge in Boston on Thursday seemed skeptical of the Trump administration's argument that the food aid program could be suspended for the first time in its history because of the ongoing government shutdown. **Nation & World**

By Angie Leventis Lourgos
Chicago Tribune

Joanna Martínez already spends much of her day worrying about the rising cost of food and how she can afford enough healthy meals to feed her two daughters.

Now the single mother, who lives in Chicago's Logan Square neighborhood, is terrified as she braces for an anticipated loss of federal food aid from the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program, commonly known as SNAP or food stamps, in just a few days.

Martínez, 36, is one of more than 40 million Americans poised to lose their SNAP benefits on Saturday as the second-longest federal government shutdown in U.S. history drags on.

"I'm trying to come up with a plan," she said. "But I'm still scared."

The U.S. Department of Agriculture posted a

Turn to SNAP, Page 4



Students work on a math problem in groups during a seventh-grade math class on Thursday at Monroe Middle School in Wheaton. **DOMINIC DI PALERMO/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

State graduation rates hit high, but test score changes cloud the picture

By Kate Armanini
Chicago Tribune

Illinois' high school graduation rate has hit a 15-year high, as students continue to show academic growth above pre-pandemic levels, state officials announced Thursday with the release of the 2025 Illinois Report Card.

The state's four-year graduation rate reached 89%, up 6.2% from 2024. Students recorded progress in other key areas, including an increase in the number of ninth graders on track

to graduate and a dip in chronic absenteeism.

The annual Illinois State Board of Education report offers a comprehensive analysis of academic, demographic and financial data for every school and district in the state.

"We have a lot to celebrate in this year's report card," state Superintendent of Education Tony Sanders told reporters at a media briefing last week. "The 2025 report card shows clear and encouraging progress across our educational system."

Based on the new testing benchmarks, 52.4% of students were proficient in English language arts, 38.4% in math and 44.6% in science.

This year, ISBE changed how it analyzes students' standardized test scores, making it difficult to provide a clear picture of year-over-year progress. But student growth — a measure of how much students have improved compared with their peers — continues to show that learning progress

Turn to Schools, Page 5

Dad released from ICE custody

A 40-year-old Portage Park man is coming home to his teenage daughter battling cancer, nearly two weeks after his arrest in Niles sparked outrage. **Chicagoland, Page 2**

Council objects to head tax plan

A majority of aldermen signed a letter Thursday objecting to reinstating Chicago's head tax and other components of Mayor Brandon Johnson's budget. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Too old to go trick-or-treating?

Teenagers with no costumes ringing the doorbell? In some parts of the state, that's illegal. But Halloween age restrictions have a deep and complicated history. **A+E**

